

KF1 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Karis Fellowships is more than an education. We anticipate that regular attendance at the weekly KF meetings will actually change you and set you on a glorious path, the path that God intended for you. At these meetings, you will learn to use tools that will help you in your daily life. One of these tools is the practice of mindfulness and Christian meditation. In Karis Fellowships, mindfulness means that we train our minds to be aware of what is happening inside and around us. In meditation, we train ourselves to rest in stillness and connect with God. It is a kind of waiting before the Lord. Although, to a great extent, we have lost the traditions of mindfulness and meditation in the modern church, Christians have used these practices for centuries to help them walk with God.

Mindfulness and meditation are difficult for everyone. That’s why they are called spiritual disciplines. Disciples are learners, and a discipline is something that you have to learn. Learning any new skill takes time, patience, and practice. Karis Fellowships supports you in the process of learning. Think of your mind as a young puppy learning to sit still on command.

Why is it important to be able to sit still? When you have learned to sit still in the quiet, you can use that same ability to find stillness when events invite you to judge or react compulsively. In your KF training, you will uncover and tackle fears and motives of which you were previously unaware. You have suppressed your awareness of these fears and motives because they do not meet your standards of perfection. When you judge something about yourself as bad, you want to suppress it, resist it, or change it into something else. You cannot face it squarely and deal with it as it actually is—just another area of your life that needs healing and training. Mindfulness practice develops your ability to stop reacting out of judgment, fear, and hurt pride, all of which quench the Spirit’s influence over your choices. If you can stop, step back, and observe, you can then approach the problem without bias, ready to explore how to heal. Mindfulness practice empowers you to stop judging and start responding in love.

We begin with the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹ This mindfulness exercise teaches us important skills. First, we learn to give our physical bodies permission to talk to us; second, we learn to notice our breathing; and third, we learn that mindful breathing helps us experience ourselves as unified material and spiritual creatures. The **3-Minute Breathing Space** trains us to connect to our breathing when we are under stress

and, also, to disconnect from our compulsive judgments, reactions, and stories. We can simply breathe and observe.

When we talk about stories in KF training, we mean the narratives that we tell ourselves and others in order to explain our feelings and choices. Stories relieve tension. They are often based on what we compulsively need to believe, and we create them to support our illusions and restore our pride. For example, when we are hurt, we feel vulnerable and our pride is wounded. We then tell a story about how someone has hurt us. We judge that person's behavior as bad and feel a need for revenge. Our judgments restore our pride and fuel our sense of injustice about the way that we have been treated. In our story, we might unconsciously exaggerate feelings and embellish experiences to make ourselves appear more interesting and to control the attention of others. We use stories in this way to help rescue us from our feelings of worthlessness; our stories make us feel significant.

Follow these basic instructions as I guide you. When you notice that your mind is drifting, as it certainly will, gently recall your thoughts by observing your breath.

We start with **AWARENESS**.

Prepare your body for mindfulness practice. Sit up straight, if you can. Imagine the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Lengthen your spine by straightening the back of your neck and drop your chin a little. Plant your feet on the ground or, if you are sitting on the floor, plant your tailbone into the earth. If possible, close your eyes. Then ask yourself: *What is my experience right now—in thoughts, in feelings, and in my body's sensations?* (Repeat) Get to know yourself as you are right now. Observe for thirty seconds, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Move to **GATHERING**.

Notice your breathing, just as it is. Notice each in-breath and each out-breath as they follow one after the other. Use your breath as an anchor to bring you into the present moment and to help you find a place of stillness and unbiased awareness. Observe your breathing without judgment and release any thoughts of right or wrong. Breathe and observe for another thirty seconds. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Now move to **EXPANDING**.

Expand your awareness to include a sense of yourself as a composite whole of mind, emotions, and physical sensations, including the part of you that is observing all of those things. (Pause) Notice how your body moves with each breath. (Pause) Notice your posture and what your face is doing. (Pause) Observe and breathe for thirty seconds. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Now pause, and redirect your mind back to the meeting. It takes a long time to learn how to make the most of the **3-Minute Breathing Space**, and most of us are still learning. Be kind to yourself as you train and learn.

We practice mindfulness to maintain our awareness of who we are and what we are experiencing in the present moment, no matter what is going on around us. The **3-Minute Breathing Space** provides a way to step out of automatic pilot mode and away from our habitual reactions to events. It helps us learn to reconnect thoughtfully with what is happening around us. The key skill in practicing this meditation is to simply observe without judgment.

If you haven't already done so, begin your own daily practice this week, spending one minute on each of the three steps. Try to set aside time in the morning and then again later in the day. It might help to attach

this practice to a habit that is already in place. You can practice the **3-Minute Breathing Space** using these teaching notes to guide you, or you can download the instructions under the **Toolbox** menu on the KF website. Alternatively, you can call this meeting's playback number and follow along with the group again.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

I hope that you will review the notes from the **KF Introductory Meeting**. You can also read the **Expanded Version** of the introductory lesson to get a more detailed explanation of what we do in KF. Bold print in the body of the text indicates documents, information, and KF tools that are available on the website.

At this point, you might ask yourself the question: *How do I know when I am misoriented?*

In the **KF Introductory Meeting**, you learned that in Karis Fellowships we use the term *misorientation* when referring to our neurotic behaviors and compulsive drives. We often cannot spot the signs that indicate misorientation because our misoriented behaviors and reactions seem so normal to us. When you are misoriented, you are no longer oriented toward God and His design but have oriented toward the demands and pride of the Idol Self. Your habitual ways of thinking, feeling, and reacting have become an autopilot system that short-circuits your ability to make conscious choices and, also, your ability to consider the consequences of the choices you make; you don't even notice what you are actually doing. You automatically defend your reactions as justified and rational, and any evidence to the contrary is immediately flushed from your awareness because it doesn't fit your ideas of right and wrong, good and bad, fair and unfair. When you are misoriented, you become hardened and must engage with life through a closed system that can only filter and evaluate what it already believes and knows.

Judging creates tension and anxiety, and tension and anxiety trigger self-protection. You cannot learn in that environment. In mindfulness training, however, you learn to observe without judgment, which allows real evidence to penetrate your conscious mind. When you stop judging information as good or bad, right or wrong, fair or unfair, you can relax, observe, and learn. Your goal is to stop evaluating and simply observe what is true about yourself in this moment. How misoriented are you?

Your first step toward recognizing misorientation is to notice yourself. You observe what you are doing right now within your own mind and body, and in your choices. With mindful observation, you explore and compare your reactions in similar situations and look for patterns. As you continue in your training, you might also look for signs of positive change. Step by step, you will learn to identify healthy and unhealthy behaviors, feelings, and thoughts. For a moment, you lay aside the idea that others are the cause of your misorientation. You begin to accept that you yourself are the cause.

Feelings seem like a good place to start, but do you know that most of us don't know what we are actually feeling? Anger can feel like sadness. Anxiety can feel like rage. Shame can feel like numbness. We often suppress our real and, perhaps, unacceptable feelings, and we have developed highly effective strategies to prevent those feelings from coming to the surface of our awareness. When we were young, we suppressed our feelings to protect our True Self; we now suppress our feelings to protect our Idol Self.

Some people go about their lives almost numb until they feel anger or a reckless optimism. They will not allow themselves to feel anything else.

I once worked with a young man who said that he didn't have any feelings at all about a particular situation. I told him to look at his hands. His hands were clenched together as if he were suppressing panic. He then admitted that maybe he felt a little tense!

Here are a few examples of the feelings offered by experienced KF members that could very well indicate misorientation:

- Strain or tension
- Lack of gratitude
- The inability to appreciate what we have or what another is doing
- Chronic discontent or envy
- Contempt for oneself or for others; despising oneself or others
- Disrespect for our own or another's reality, beliefs, and aspirations
- Suddenly falling in love or plunging into hate
- Outbursts of rage or despair
- An overriding sense of worthlessness
- Helplessness or creating victim scenarios
- Defensiveness
- A strong desire for revenge, justice, or control
- A strong desire to help, rescue, or fix
- A strong desire to escape, avoid, or withdraw
- Irritability
- Stagnation or fatigue
- Hurt feelings
- Fears, phobias, and panic
- Craving, addictive behaviors
- Euphoria
- Numbness or no feelings
- Paralyzing doubt or confusion

Behaviors can also indicate that something is amiss. Here are a few red flags to consider:

- Blaming others for how we feel
- Judging and evaluating events with strong feelings
- Excessive reactions
- Obsessing or nagging
- Irrational resistance
- Disregard for balance and limitations, like overspending or overcommitting
- Choosing instant gratification; grabbing it now without forethought or plan
- Avoiding change, exploration, or personal development
- Taking control and using force; going into battle mode
- Shutting down or escaping
- Creating drama or soap opera scenarios

- Victimizing ourselves or others
- Reacting in old unproductive patterns
- Sacrificing ourselves or others to avoid conflict, to please, or to win
- Creating suffering for ourselves and others
- Refusing to take responsibility or share the load
- Taking too much responsibility for everything
- Carelessness or recklessness
- Procrastination
- Restlessness, like compulsive activity or compulsive talking

These are just a few of the symptoms of misorientation, but this list is a good place to start! Bear in mind that misorientation is always egocentric, meaning that nothing and no one else matters except what you need or want. There is a kind of heedlessness, a disregard for other factors in your decisions and activities. Only your feelings or needs count. You might think: “I’ve got to do this now to feel better. It’s all up to me. Only I know what is right. I have to change this because . . .” Misorientation has the feeling of an impulsive, compelling priority, unplanned and without balance, in which no one else’s opinion matters—not even God’s.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Compassionate Father, I present myself now, as I am, to become what You would have me be. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

This month we are considering KF Confession 1:

We confess that we have worshipped and served an Idol Self that we have created.

How did we turn from the real God who created us and create a god of our own? In the NHG book study, which we all endured together, we learned that our backgrounds, our conflicts about other people, our deep anxiety, and our need for self-confidence all pressed us into seeking an imagined safe place that could only be maintained and defended with certain behaviors. These behaviors seemed to give us some degree of relief from our anxiety, but they still did not provide the security and self-confidence that we dreamed of. We then believed that *more* would be better, so we took those behaviors to an extreme. We became convinced that if we could perform perfectly, we would have what we seek. That dream hardened into a chronic search for glory, an imagined place of perfect security and effortless superiority. We became completely egocentric in this search. We no longer took any real interest in other people, nor did we notice their struggles with the same problem.

The search for glory uses up a lot of energy. Our goal in Karis Fellowships is to redirect that creative and abundant energy toward our true glory. As we learned in the **KF Introductory Meeting**, our true glory

reveals our original design, and our original design reveals the glory of our Creator. Our glory is this: *to fulfill our design as creatures who uniquely represent God's character in this material world. (Repeat)*

How does the Bible first describe our glory? Let's look at **Genesis 1:26–28**. This translation is from the *New American Standard Bible*.²

²⁶Then God said, "Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness; and let them rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over the cattle and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth." ²⁷God created man in His own image, in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them. ²⁸God blessed them; and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth, and subdue it; and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over every living thing that moves about on the earth."

The following translation is from the *Expanded Bible*.³

²⁶Then God said, "Let us make human beings in our image and likeness. And let them rule [have dominion] over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky [heavens], over the tame animals [beasts; livestock], over all the earth, and over all the small crawling animals on the earth." ²⁷So God created [1:1] human beings [man; ^cthe Hebrew *adam* can mean human beings, humankind, person, man, or the proper name Adam] in his image [^creflecting God's nature/character and representing him in the world]. In the image of God he created them. He created them male and female. ²⁸God blessed them and said [^tto them], "Have many children and grow in number [^tBe fruitful and multiply]. Fill [...and fill] the earth and be its master [subdue it]. Rule [^tHave dominion] over the fish in the sea and over the birds in the sky [heavens] and over every living thing that moves on the earth."

Take a deep breath.

First, we see in this passage that all human beings are created in God's image—men and women, boys and girls. Both sexes reveal the image of God. Human beings were designed to offer to this world the likeness of God's character, trustworthiness, and creative wealth. We are not designed to mold ourselves into an image that we then worship and serve.

Next, we see in this passage that we have work to do. In the **KF Introductory Meeting**, we learned that Jesus glorified God by finishing His work. We are invited to do the same. Our job is to rule over other creatures and subdue the material world. In other words, we are called to influence this world according to God's mercy and truth. Note that we were not designed to rule over each other. That feels a little scary for the neurotic!

Finally, we are designed to be fruitful and multiply. Our ability to create other eternal souls is similar to God's creative ability. However, unlike God, we cannot do it alone; we need a partner. Sex differences reveal the nature of our relationship with God. Paul teaches that the communion between male and female in the marriage relationship represents and explores the communion that human creatures have with Christ.⁴ This is so important. The unity of one sex with the other reflects our unity with a Divine Being quite different from ourselves but with similar characteristics. Just as we cannot generate children by

ourselves, we cannot be saved or be complete by ourselves. We need to co-labor with God in our own restoration; we cannot do it alone. Only God knows what our glory will look like.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord of Glory, I am ready to explore my glory. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

A list of the Fruit of the Spirit is found in Galatians 5:22–23. Our goal in Karis Fellowships is to consistently experience and produce this Fruit in our lives, and to do that, we need healing. In the KF meetings, we heal personally and, also, as a group. During this portion of the meeting, we integrate what we have learned so that the Fruit of the Spirit can flow naturally out of our healing. This opportunity for healing and integration makes KF attendance your best friend right now. On the KF website, you can read about the vision that Karis Fellowships has for you as a child of God. We believe that you can become a powerful and creative instrument for good in this world.

Following the regular meeting integration, I am sometimes able to share with the group something that I am aware of. This is not an arbitrary guess on my part but a gift given by God to this community. Just allow the gift to work. You may feel a physical sensation, get very sleepy, or feel like you need to stretch or move. Simply let your experience be what it is. If you feel nothing, that is perfectly all right too.

We will begin with a mindfulness practice that helps us allow our feelings and passing thoughts to come to our awareness without judging or reacting to them. We learn to explore rather than suppress. I call this practice the **FAITH Process**. We learn to practice our faith while we feel our feelings.

- F** is for Feelings
- A** is for Awareness without judgment
- I** is for Inquiry: What is my body saying?
- T** is for Talk to Jesus
- H** is for Heal

During this part of the meeting, you might like to take some notes. You could use the back of your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you might want to start a KF journal. Now, assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider fulfilling your created design. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider fulfilling your created design*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can

learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Graciously allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush thoughts or feelings from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider fulfilling your created design*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing as you *consider fulfilling your created design*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what resistance, confusion, or even terror feels like in your body. Perhaps you feel joy or curiosity. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider fulfilling your created design*. *(Pause)* Are your thoughts pleasant, unpleasant, or vague and slippery? Just breathe and observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider your created design? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge your design as good or evil? *(Pause)* Observe whatever you are experiencing as just information. Breathe deeply, and allow your exhale to be long and relaxed. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created you to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you do when they have *considered fulfilling their created design*. You can read about that in the Psalms. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in explanations and reactions. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for the whole human race. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

Karis Fellowships sends out regular emails during the week with portions of the **Expanded Version** of the KF teaching notes. We call this gift the **KF Compass**. Please write to admin@karisfellowships.com if you would like to receive these emails.

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams and John D Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² Gen. 1:26–28 (New American Standard Bible).

³ Gen. 1:26–28 (Expanded Bible) *Bible Gateway*, accessed April 24, 2016. The letters T, C, and L are abbreviations for Translation, Comment, and Literal, respectively.

www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=Genesis+1%3A26-28&version=EXB.

⁴ Eph. 5:31–33.